



REEL/ REAL (clockwise, from far left) A poster for *Lock Upp*; stills from *Shark Tank India*; *Dance India Dance*; and *Bigg Boss*



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and the host Kangana Ranaut's own acerbic preoccupations. Strangely, when you put them all together in a room, the acidity dilutes and the initial ideological antagonisms give way to a fragile coexistence. *Lock Upp* reminds us of how we sometimes confuse our opinions for our entire being. It shows us that our current participatory culture can be renewed, expanding beyond one's ideology and that this can only happen when we share space; that even after she has dismissed him as consummately unfunny, Kangana can eventually crack a smile at a joke Munawar makes.

This "*kone-kone se*" rhetoric, of hooping in Indians from every corner, is not entirely of gloss value. It makes economic sense, too. In the summer of 2007, a valuable lesson was learnt when the finals of *Indian Idol*—one of the first shows to use SMS votes—pitted Prashant Tamang, a Kolkata Police constable from Darjeeling, against Amit Paul, a 'singing sensation' from Shillong. Overnight, there were fan clubs brewing across the two towns, gallons of votes being sent via SMS through free PCOs and mobile recharge vouchers. In some episodes, the participants were even carted to temples and dargahs and asked to sing songs from disparate regions and folk traditions. This did, at times, backfire. As Parimal Bhattacharya writes in his book *No Path in Darjeeling Is Straight*, "In one of the episodes [...] when Prashant was made to dress up like and mimic a Gorkha chowkidar in a Hindi film and sing the song, it sparked outrage in the hills."

Since *Sa Re Ga Ma Pa* aired on Zee5 in 1995, the landscape of reality TV has come a long way, altered to consciously bring in ethnic, religious and sexual diversity. A lot of these shows in India have borrowed from formats incubated to perfection in the West—*Big Brother* to *Big Boss*, *Masterchef Australia* to *Masterchef India*, *Fear Factor* to *Khatron Ke Khiladi*, *Power of 10* to *Dus Ka Dum*.

Silvio Waisbord, professor of media and public affairs at the George Washington University, calls these formats "culturally specific but nationally neutral". It is perhaps this relentless balance between the specific and the neutral, between the familiar and the unfamiliar, that makes the format of the reality show a promising, pertinent hub of cultural production. ■

–Prathyush Parasuraman

IN REAL TIME

Reality TV milestones in India



Kaun Banega Crorepati (2000–)

Adapted from Who Wants to Be a Millionaire, *this quiz show resuscitated host Amitabh Bachchan's career. It was the first to actively lasso in people from smaller towns. Within a year, they were receiving around 200,000 calls a day from potential contestants.*



Indian Matchmaking (2020–)

Sima Taparia, a marriage consultant from Mumbai, tries to find suitable, marriageable boys and girls for her clients. What ensued, from Netflix's glossy-paged reality show, was fresh fodder for memes and incensed opinion pieces.



Sacch Ka Saamna (2009–2012)

Adapted from The Moment of Truth, *where participants are plugged to a polygraph test and asked increasingly personal, violable questions, this show tested the limits of the audience, with many protesting its invasive, morally unacceptable voyeurism.*